

Review Article

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Abstract: Endresen, Cecilie. “Is the Albanian’s religion really ‘Albanianism’?: Religion and nation according to Muslim and Christian leaders in Albania.” Vol. 31. Harrassowitz Verlag, 2013.

Endresen, Cecilie. “A Fantastic People and Its Enemies: An Analysis of an Emerging Albanian Mythology.” *Handbook of Conspiracy Theory and Contemporary Religion*. Brill, 2018. 343-360. .

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A vagrant researcher from Norway has wandered in the forests of Albania. Locals spoke of her as a Scandinavian religious anthropologist with a taste for the forbidden. Like some character from Lars von Trier’s *Antichrist*, she set out on a shamanic quest: to unpick the dark seams of Albania’s mythology. She carried with her the eccentric scriptures of *Sazan Guri* and *Petro Zheji*, a GPS phone, satellite maps, and—perhaps for a touch of equilibrium—Ardian Vehbiu’s *The Disruptive Mr. Shyti*.

Thus provisioned, she slipped into the woods, beyond the gaze of academia’s gatekeepers.

Yet when she returned home to write, she was more lost than when she had left. She traded her intuition and local insight for reputation, transmuting lived experience into scholarly currency. By attempting to frame her mystical encounters for a European readership, seeking to rationalize them for an epistemic community deaf to the irrational, she diminished what she had experienced. To communicate with her peers, she abandoned the ineffable, producing articles that failed to capture her mystical experience.

From years of fieldwork between 2005 and 2014, Endresen assembled a dense tapestry of sources: interviews with authors, diplomats, and ordinary Albanians, alongside analyses of popular texts. She lingered on works such as Mathieu Aref’s *Pelazgët—Origjina jonë e mohuar* (2007), which traces Albanian descent to divine origins, and Petro Zheji’s *Zoti Shqiptar* (2008), which proclaims Albanian as the very language of the gods. These writings, often blending pseudolinguistics with esotericism, claim that Homer himself spoke an Albanian dialect and that the *Iliad* originates from Albanian etymologies. According to Endresen, such theories are amplified by mass media—the television series *Enigma—Sekretet e Tokës Shqiptare* (2012)—and by social networks, particularly Facebook groups with thousands of members, which popularize Pelasgian primacy and link it to broader conspiracies involving Freemasons, UFOs, and New Age mysticism.

Endresen situates these myths within Albania’s turbulent post-communist history: the trauma of the 1997 pyramid schemes, the frustration of EU integration, and the scars left by Enver Hoxha’s atheist regime, which razed churches and mosques alike. She draws parallels to 19th-century romantic nationalism and post-Yugoslav identity crises, interpreting Pelasgianism as a “religious laboratory” that attempts to reconstruct faith out of ruins. Ancient

Egyptian, Mayan, and Buddhist elements are woven into a pan-Albanian cosmology that seeks to reconcile isolation and fracture.

For political reasons, however, Endresen discards the interstellar layer of the conspiracy—the whispers that beneath Pelasgian myths lie UFO narratives fused with local lore, that Albanian artifacts and etymologies conceal extraterrestrial blueprints. She argues that national mythology is a double-edged sword. On one side, a creative response to trauma, offering coherence to a disoriented society; on the other, a breeding ground for xenophobia, revisionism, and fanaticism. Albanians, she argues, heal their wounds of isolation and economic ruin by envisioning themselves as a chosen people, bearers of humanity’s original language, something reserved for a nation in the Middle East—while stigmatizing those outside this mythic circle. She critiques this reliance on “stigmatized knowledge”: epistemologies that reject mainstream scholarship in favor of alternative truths, seductive in their defiance of authority.

In doing so, she conspires against Albania, unveiling what she takes to be the deeper secret: that its mythologies are not revelations of truth but coping mechanisms for a nation’s cultivated sense of victimhood. That Albanians have cast themselves as the dispossessed heirs of a primordial legacy, robbed by Greeks, Serbs, and Slavs. Yet I doubt she ever pierced the core of Albania’s myth. Like the Beatles’ *Norwegian Wood*—or Murakami’s faltering novel of the same name of an impenetrable girl—she touched only the surface, never the fire beneath. And so she risks becoming just another foreign traveler, like those British or Austrian wanderers a century before her, chasing the “romantic past of humanity” precisely because she could not come to terms with modernity.

In his book on Albanian conspiracy theories, while contemplating the different functions of Albanian conspiracy theories in political, sociological, and literary terms, Robert Weisal¹⁷ notes a third function of Albanian conspiracy theories—one that goes beyond the mere desire for amusement, whether on the part of the narrator or the audience. The narrator’s impulse to fictionalize and exaggerate political events often stems from an ambition to be recognized as a writer and to find a worthy audience for his work, a privilege usually reserved for those with political backing or ties to the establishment. Similarly, the willingness of the audience to engage with conspiracy theorists derives from a parallel ambition: the wish to belong to a select group of people who know the truth, a secret, or at least a version of it. They entertain the idea that they understand and even identify with the narrator’s struggle for attention and recognition. This is the case with the conspiracy theories of Pelasgism—concerning the supposed extraterrestrial origins of the Albanian nation—which have eluded authors like Endresen.

What Sazan Guri and Petro Zheji have in common is their desire to be recognized as writers and intellectuals. Both are aware that their ideas are not accepted by the mainstream academic community, yet they persist in promoting them within the same academic establishment and tradition to which they rightly belong. Their conspiracy theories about the origins of the Albanian nation are a way to assert their ambitions as writers and to find an audience that places them alongside similarly successful conspiracy writers such

¹⁷See his chapter *Introduction*, “Handbook of Albanian Conspiracy Theories”, *forthcoming*.

as Ismail Kadare, who wove conspiracy theories into his novels, using them to blur the distinction between truth and fiction and to explore themes of power, betrayal, and identity on both domestic and international levels. Later writers of lesser repute, such as Ben Blushi,¹⁸ and more modern and internationally known writers, such as Ardian Vehbiu,¹⁹ have also used conspiracy theories in their works.

¹⁸See Mërtir Mërtiri, “Arab-Islamic Conspiracies in Albania” In “Handbook of Albanian Conspiracy Theories”, ed. Robert Weisal *forthcoming*.

¹⁹See “Bolero” about a conspiracy in New York, “Rrefimet e Maks Gjerazit”, or “Cose portate da mare” about the conspiracy of a radio listener